

FOR FAMILIES WALKING A PARENT THROUGH WHAT COMES NEXT



The Senior Transition

*A Family's Guide to the Conversation,
the House, the Money, the Care,
and the People Trying to Take Advantage*

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A FREE CHAPTER FROM

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by Ryan Riggins

CHAPTER 13

The Predator's Playbook: A Wholesaler's Confession

This chapter is going to make some people uncomfortable. It might even make you angry. Good. It should. This is a look behind the curtain at the world I used to live in: the world of real estate wholesaling and investing. While not every investor is a predator, the industry is built on a playbook that is designed to find people when they are vulnerable and take advantage of them. And there is no one more vulnerable than a senior homeowner in distress, or the adult children trying to help them from a thousand miles away.

I'm going to show you how it works. I'm going to give you the plays. Not so you can run them, but so you can see them coming and protect your family from them. This isn't about being cynical; it's about being prepared.

Let me tell you about a deal that still sticks with me, one that was a turning point in my own conscience. A man named David and his wife Sarah contacted me. They were trying to sell his mother's house. The mother, Deborah, had severe dementia and was in a full-time care facility, and David held the legal authority to act for her, so the decision, and all the weight of it, fell on him and Sarah. The house was a mess. And I don't mean a little cluttered. Deborah had been an avid QVC shopper for decades, and the house was packed to the gills with unopened boxes, clothes with the tags still on, and every gadget you can imagine. To make matters worse, her grandson,

David's nephew, had been living there rent-free, treating the place like a frat house: beer cans, garbage, and a general layer of filth. On top of all that, the house had a home equity line of credit on it at a crippling 14% interest rate. The payment was \$1,200 a month, and David was covering it out of his own pocket while the house sat there going nowhere. Every month this family waited cost them another \$1,200.

This was a wholesaler's dream scenario. It checks every box: clutter, deferred maintenance, a distressed seller, and a motivated, overwhelmed family. I made them an offer of \$100,000. They were so desperate, so beaten down by the situation, that they took my offer to the nephew and told him if he could get a loan for that amount, they'd sell it to him just to be done with it. He threw a fit, trashed the house even more, and then, out of pure spite, cut the power, leaving a full fridge and freezer to rot in the Carolina heat. The smell was unimaginable.

We eventually settled on \$105,000, and Deborah's loan was paid off at the closing table. The \$1,200-a-month bleed stopped the day we bought it, and I got to feel like the man who stopped it. I was happy. I even helped David and Sarah move two truckloads of stuff to a storage unit for Deborah to look at in her moments of clarity. I felt like a good guy. Then we put \$55,000 into the renovation and sold the house for \$295,000. After every cost came out, my profit was right around \$100,000.

Here's the confession, the part that eats at me. I could have paid them \$150,000 and still cleared a healthy profit. And the real number is worse than that: sold as-is, the way I would sell it for a family today, that house was worth about \$200,000. With a cleanout and maybe \$8,000 in strategic repairs, it would have brought \$230,000 to \$240,000. The path I now walk families through would have put roughly \$100,000 more in Deborah's pocket than the \$105,000 they took. Instead, that money ended up in mine. They had no idea what the house was worth or what their options were. They only knew the clock was ticking at \$1,200 a month. Their desperation was my leverage.

That's Play #1 in the Predator's Playbook: **Weaponize the Overwhelm.** Find a house that is so cluttered and appears to be in such disrepair that the family can't see a way out. Make them feel like the mess is a problem too big to solve, one that only a cash offer can fix. You're not buying a house; you're buying a problem. And you convince the seller that the problem is so big, so awful, that they should be grateful to you for taking it off their hands. They will give up tens of thousands of dollars in equity just to make the problem go away.

Play #2 is **Exploit the Unknown.** I once bought a 2,900-square-foot house from another wholesaler. The seller never even met me. The deal was done entirely through an intermediary. The house needed a new roof and some cosmetic updating, but it had no mortgage. It was free and clear. We bought it for \$98,000, put about \$60,000 into it, and sold it for \$350,000. After every closing and holding cost came out, our profit was \$168,000. If that seller had worked with an advisor instead of a wholesaler, they could have sold it as-is for at least \$200,000. If they had put just \$20,000 into smart, strategic repairs, they could have sold it for \$250,000 or more. But they didn't know that. They didn't know what the house was worth, they didn't know what it needed, and they didn't know their options. The wholesaler's entire business model is built on being the only person in the room who knows the true value of the property and the true cost of the repairs.

Play #3 is even sneakier: **Let the System Do the Dirty Work.** I knew an investor who would target homeowners who were behind on their HOA dues. He wouldn't try to help them or contact them. He would just wait, circling like a vulture, until the HOA foreclosed on the property. Then, he would negotiate directly with the HOA to buy the house for the cost of the back dues and fees, and the homeowner's equity went with it. He was using a legal process to do his dirty work for him. The same tactic works with tax debt in the states that sell tax liens: an investor pays a few thousand dollars in back taxes and, if the debt is never paid, moves to take a house worth many times that. And here is the part that should keep you up at night: none of it

requires breaking a single law. The system will take your family's equity with a straight face, which is exactly why your family has to see it coming.

These aren't isolated incidents. This is the business. It's a system for finding people in pain and turning their pain into profit. The "We Buy Houses" signs you see stapled to telephone poles? They're not looking for ugly houses. They're looking for distressed situations. They're looking for families who don't know their options. They're looking for people who will trade their equity for a quick and easy solution.

I'm not telling you this to scare you. I'm telling you this because you need to understand the game. When that friendly, earnest young man sends you a handwritten letter saying he and his wife are looking for a home in the neighborhood and fell in love with your mom's, he's not doing it because he loves the azaleas. He's doing it because he sees an opportunity. He's running a play from the Predator's Playbook. Your best defense is to know the plays better than he does.

I know, because I used to write those letters. I still mail letters to senior homeowners today, pulled from the same public records those buyers use. The difference is the first thing mine say: there is no offer in this letter. Same list. Opposite letter. And the next chapter is that promise turned into a working system.

Tools for this chapter: Got one of those letters? Senior Scam Protection walks through how the cash-buyer and wholesaler plays work, and how to stop them: rigginsstrategicsolutions.com/book/scams

Riggins Rule: If someone is rushing you to make a decision, the decision is almost certainly good for them and bad for you.

Want the rest of the book?

The Senior Transition walks your family through all of it: the conversation, the house, the money, the care, and the people trying to take advantage.

Get the paperback or Kindle at **rigginsstrategicsolutions.com/book/amazon**

Every tool mentioned in the book, chapter by chapter, is at **rigginsstrategicsolutions.com/book**

About Ryan

Ryan Riggins spent years as a house flipper and cash buyer before switching sides. Today he helps families figure out what to do with a parent's house when Mom or Dad is moving into care, before anyone signs anything.

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